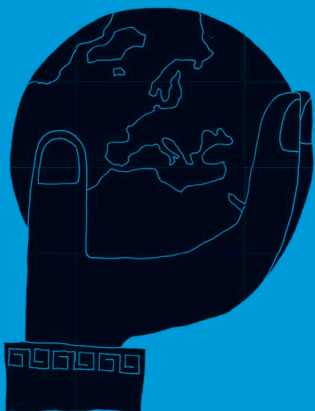




THERE IS NOTHING IMPOSSIBLE TO HE WHO WILL TRY

THE CONQUESTS OF ALEXANDER THE GREAT
(4TH CENTURY BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Hellenistic world

BEFORE

449 BCE The end of the Persian Wars leaves Persia in control of Greek kingdoms in Asia Minor.

359 BCE Philip II of Macedon begins his rise to power and develops innovative military technology and tactics.

338 BCE Philip II defeats the Greek states and becomes undisputed leader of Greece.

AFTER

321 BCE After Alexander's death, squabbling between his generals breaks out into widespread civil war.

278 BCE Alexander's generals establish three Hellenistic kingdoms in Greece, the Middle East, and Europe.

30 BCE Emperor Octavian annexes Egypt, the last Hellenistic kingdom, for Rome.

In one of the fastest and most daring military expansions in history, Alexander the Great, the young king of Macedon in the Balkans, blazed a trail of conquest across most of the known world of his day, and set in motion a process of Hellenization—the spread of Greek culture and its fusion with non-Greek, Eastern traditions—which endured for centuries.

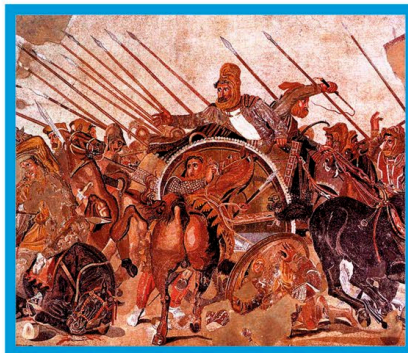
Alexander's father, Philip II, had transformed this peripheral state into a formidable military power, and had waged campaigns against his neighbors that culminated in Macedon's domination over all of

Greece. When he was assassinated in 336 BCE, Philip had been planning an expedition to West Asia, to free the former Greek city-states now ruled by the world's superpower, the Persian Empire. After securing the Macedonian throne by destroying his rivals, Alexander set about pursuing his father's quest, while satisfying his own thirst for glory.

King of the world

After forcing the other Greek city-states to accept his authority, in 334 BCE Alexander marched into Asia Minor (modern-day Turkey) at the head of an army of 43,000 foot soldiers and 5,500 cavalry. At its heart lay the Macedonian phalanx, a well-drilled, tight-knit corps of 15,000 men armed with the *sarissa*, a pike that was up to 23ft (7m) long. When combined with the shocking cavalry charge provided by the king's personal bodyguard, the Companions, the formation proved irresistible.

After an initial victory over the Persians at the River Granicus in the northwest, Alexander pressed on across Asia Minor. He stopped at Gordium in the central kingdom of Phrygia, where tradition held that he who could untie a complex



In this late Roman mosaic, Darius III is shown fighting at Issus in 333 BCE. Alexander conquered the Persian king's empire and destroyed its capital in Persepolis without suffering a defeat.

See also: The Persian Wars 44–45 ■ Athenian democracy 46–51 ■ The assassination of Julius Caesar 58–65 ■ Belisarius retakes Rome 76–77 ■ The founding of Baghdad 86–93 ■ The fall of Constantinople 138–41

East–West **cultural exchange** begins from an era of **Persian Wars**, with western provinces of Persian Empire becoming **Hellenized** and Macedonians adopting aspects of **Persian culture**.

Alexander's conquests force the rapid synthesis of Greek and Asian cultures, laying seeds of the Hellenistic age.

Hellenistic learning survives the fall of Rome in the **Byzantine Empire** and in the **Translation Movement** of the **Islamic Caliphate**.

Hellenized societies in Egypt and West Asia **assimilated** into Roman Empire.

knot made by the city's founder, would conquer the entire continent. Alexander, in a typically forthright move, cut the knot with his sword. He went on to twice defeat the far superior forces gathered by Darius III, the Persian emperor—at Issus (on the southern coast of Asia Minor) in 333 BCE and Gaugamela (in modern Iraq) in 331 BCE, subduing Egypt in the interval.

Having forced the Persians into submission, Alexander drove his troops eastward, across mountains,

deserts, and rivers into Afghanistan and Central Asia, and on to the Indian Punjab, ruthlessly crushing all resistance. He would have pushed further into India, but in 325 BCE his exhausted men refused to go on.

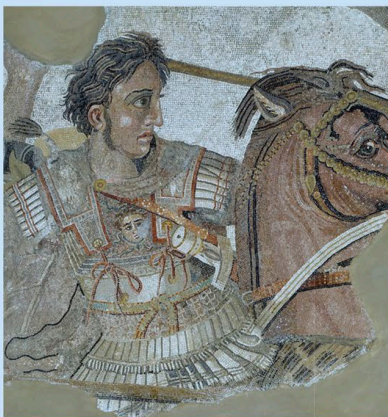
The Hellenistic legacy

Alexander was now the king of a vast and ethnically diverse empire that included 70 newly founded cities, united by a common Greek culture, customs, and language, and linked by trade routes; although

the process of Hellenization was already underway in the western half of Persia before his expedition, Alexander had accelerated its spread throughout the Middle East.

In 323 BCE, Alexander died—most likely from disease but perhaps by poisoning—without naming a successor. His empire was carved up by his leading generals, but some of the Hellenistic dynasties they founded, notably Selucid Syria and Babylon and Ptolomeic Egypt, survived until Roman times. ■

Alexander the Great



Throughout antiquity, Alexander was widely regarded as the most remarkable man who ever lived, and in terms of the breadth and duration of his renown, which saw him become a key figure in national literatures from Central Asia to Western Europe, he is one of the most famous men in history.

Born in 356 BCE, to parents who claimed descent from demigods and heroes, Alexander's education under the philosopher Aristotle ensured he was steeped in Greek legend, and he came to believe he was invincible, even divine. As a general he was decisive, bold to the

point of recklessness—with his own life and those of his men—and a brilliant tactician. He maintained the loyalty of his forces throughout his long and arduous campaign, but his quick and violent temper, fueled by his heavy drinking, occasionally spurred him to eliminate those closest to him, including his friends. Alexander died at age 32, at the height of his power. His funeral cortège was hijacked by Ptolemy, one of his generals, and diverted to Alexandria in Egypt, where his tomb was later visited by Julius Caesar, but is now lost.